

Tackling the issue of
increased terrorism
activity in the South Asia
region

Counter-Terrorism Committee (CTC)

I. Introduction

"Terrorism and deception are weapons not of the strong, but of the weak"

-Mahatma Gandhi

In South Asia, the overall threat level remains high, with several states suffering attacks since the previous global survey.¹

The rise of terrorism activities in South Asia region has become an alarming challenge, affecting the regional security and global stability. The region is facing political tensions, historical conflicts and economic difficulties that create a favourable environment for the development of extremist groups. Moreover, hard-to-control borders and limited cooperation between states facilitate the mobilisation of these networks.

Terrorist attacks not only cause loss of life and create a general climate of fear and insecurity among the population, but also affect economic growth, discouraging investment and destabilising local markets. These groups contribute significantly to radicalisation, insurgencies, amplifying internal conflicts and weakening trust in public institutions.

¹ <https://www.un.org/securitycouncil/ctc/content/south-asia>

II. Definition of Key Terms

Terrorist activities

Violent actions and threats committed by extremist groups with the purpose of inducing fear, influencing the government, intimidating the public and undermining the security of states.²

Extremism

The promotion of advancement of an ideology based on violence, hatred or intolerance.³

Guerilla Warfare

A form of unconventional warfare in which small groups of irregular military, such as rebels, or even armed civilians, including recruited children, use ambushes, sabotage, terrorism, raids, petty warfare, or hit-and-run tactics in a rebellion or a violent conflict, in order to fight against regular military, police or rival insurgent forces

International Humanitarian Law

International Humanitarian Law or IHL is a broad set of rules which aim to diminish the effects of armed conflicts as much as possible. While the majority of these laws can be found in the Geneva Conventions of 1949 and have been almost universally ratified, many other conventions following up on said rules, such as the 1997 Ottawa Convention on anti-personnel mines, do not enjoy such widespread incorporation.

Safe Havens

Areas, often found in unstable regions, where extremist groups can operate freely, plan attacks, and train without interference.

Line of Control

The de facto military boundary that separates the part of Kashmir administered by India from the part of Kashmir administered by Pakistan. It is an internationally recognised border that serves as a ceasefire line established after the first war between India and Pakistan in 1947-1948.

² <https://www.educateagainsthate.com/terrorism-definition/>

³ <https://www.educateagainsthate.com/terrorism-definition/>

III. Background Information

To understand the origins of terrorism in the South Asian region, it is essential to analyse the historical context of the region, keeping in mind that the numerous conflicts, insurgencies and geopolitical rivalries have characterised the area and have created a favourable environment for the terrorist activities. South Asia is a vast region spanning over a dozen countries, with even more cultures which tend to overlap. Socioeconomic factors constantly create friction between communities, and, in some cases, violence is encouraged by state actors.

The Kashmir war

In 1947, the creation of two independent states, India and Pakistan, generated communal violence and significant migration. The territorial dispute over Kashmir has resulted in multiple armed conflicts along the Line of Control (LoC); therefore, the insurgent and terrorist groups have exploited this situation in order to expand their activities.⁴ The continuous tensions in Kashmir have created radicalised people, especially young people, and a series of insurgents that have affected the region's security.

The Cold War and the Soviet-Afghan war

During the Cold War, South Asia became a battleground between the major powers. In 1979, the United States of America and its allies supported Afghan forces against the Soviets with resources, coordination and instructions. This intervention helped the development of terrorist and extremist groups, who learned to operate across borders and coordinate sophisticated attacks. Therefore, Afghanistan became a training ground for insurgents and allowed the formation of cross-border networks that influenced terrorist activities in Pakistan, India and other neighbouring countries.⁵

The Afghan Civil War and the “War on Terror”

The Afghan Civil War of the 1990s, the rise of the Taliban and the international intervention following the September 11th 2001 attacks, intensified terrorist activities. The borders and accidental area allowed the extremist groups to expand their operations in the neighbouring countries, including Pakistan and India. The withdrawal of international troops in 2021 consolidated the control of Taliban and create new opportunities for the radical groups,

⁴ <https://www.britannica.com/place/Kashmir-region-Indian-subcontinent/The-Kashmir-problem>

⁵ <https://www.britannica.com/event/Soviet-invasion-of-Afghanistan>

which increased the risks of attacks and regional instability.

The Sri Lankan Civil War

Sri Lanka's prolonged civil war between the government and the Liberation Tigers of Tamil Eelam (LTTE) involved widespread organised terrorism. The LTTE built advanced procurement networks and planned and coordinated attacks against civilians and government forces. Although the war formally concluded in 2009, remnants of these smuggling operations remain active. The government has taken steps towards strengthening the border security and enhancing intelligence-sharing, but the risk of extremist activities persists.

The Vietnam War

During the Vietnam War, the Ho Chi Minh Trail, which extended through Laos and Cambodia, served as a critical route for North Vietnamese forces and insurgent groups. This network facilitated the movement of fighters and the coordination of insurgent activities, contributing to the spread of extremist operations in the area.⁶

The Cambodian Civil War

In the Cambodian Civil War, various factions received substantial support from external allies. The Khmer Rouge (a radical communist movement at the time), for instance, was bolstered by Chinese military aid, which included strategic guidance, training, and advisory support. This assistance enabled the group to carry out organised insurgent campaigns and extremist operations in the region.

The Afghanistan-Pakistan Clashes

Afghanistan and Pakistan have been involved in regional proxy conflicts, which have further fuelled terrorist and insurgent activities. For instance, Pakistan has historically been accused of supporting insurgent groups fighting against Afghanistan's government forces, while also receiving military support from the United States during the Cold War. Moreover, the rugged border region between Afghanistan and Pakistan, which is difficult to monitor and control, is a key passage for the movement of insurgents and extremist groups that often operate through a mix of networks, covert routes, and informal channels. Cross-border

⁶ <https://www.britannica.com/topic/Khmer-Rouge>

movement through this area facilitates the expansion of extremist operations not only into Afghanistan and Pakistan but also into other parts of South Asia, including India and Bangladesh.

Economic and Social Causes

The economic dimension of terrorism cannot be overlooked. Widespread poverty, unemployment, and limited economic opportunities across much of South Asia have created an environment ripe for extremist recruitment and insurgent activities. The potential gains from involvement in terrorist networks have attracted not only insurgent groups but also organised crime syndicates, which sometimes collaborate with corrupt officials to facilitate extremist operations.

Moreover, there is an apparent case of convergence between different criminal and extremist activities. In South Asia, terrorism often overlaps with drug trafficking, seeing as Afghanistan and Myanmar are some of the world's largest opium producers, but also with smuggled contraband goods such as untaxed cigarettes, fuel, alcohol, or rice. More recently, extremist groups have even become involved in illicit trade of exotic animals and other black-market activities, using these channels to fund and expand their operations.⁷

IV. Major Countries and Organizations Involved

Afghanistan

Following decades of conflict, including the Soviet invasion and subsequent civil wars, Afghanistan has become a hub for extremist groups and insurgent networks. The withdrawal of U.S. and NATO forces in 2021 has created a security vacuum, consolidating Taliban control and enabling various radical groups, including the Islamic State Khorasan Province (ISKP), to expand operations. The increasing number of terrorist attacks and ongoing conflicts along Afghanistan's borders make the country a central point for extremist activities affecting the broader South Asia region.

⁷ <https://eastasiaforum.org/2024/07/31/wildlife-and-weapons-trafficking-converge-in-southeast-asia/>

India

India faces its own set of challenges related to extremist activities. The northeastern states, which share borders with Myanmar and Bangladesh, have long been targeted by insurgent groups operating cross-border networks. India's proximity to major conflict zones, such as Afghanistan, Pakistan, and Myanmar, facilitates the infiltration of extremist groups and the spread of radical ideologies. The porous borders and rise of domestic extremist groups have heightened concerns about security, prompting India to strengthen international cooperation and implement domestic counter-terrorism measures.

Pakistan

The regions of Pakistan and Afghanistan are known to be the hotspots for extremist groups. Weak governance, corruption, and militant presence have limited the effectiveness of counter-terrorism efforts. What is more, the growing rivalry between Taliban-controlled Afghanistan and Pakistan has led to the former openly facilitating terrorist attacks on the latter. Pakistan has undertaken numerous initiatives to combat terrorism, including disarmament campaigns and participation in international frameworks. However, the region remains volatile, and extremist networks continue to exploit security gaps to operate and expand their influence.⁸

Myanmar

Myanmar serves as a conduit for insurgent groups in neighbouring countries. Armed groups in the region benefit from cross-border movement and logistical networks, which facilitate the spread of extremist activities in India, Sri Lanka, and other parts of South Asia. The involvement of ethnic insurgent groups and the influx of fighters have intensified regional conflicts, posing threats to stability and security.⁹

China

China has historically influenced extremist dynamics in South Asia, particularly through the supply of military equipment and training to allied governments and factions. Chinese weapons and support have indirectly contributed to insurgent capabilities in Afghanistan, Myanmar, and Sri Lanka. While China's role is often indirect, its impact on regional security dynamics is notable.

⁸ <https://www.policyarchive.org/handle/10207/1953>

⁹ https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Terrorism_in_Myanmar

United States of America

The U.S. actively expresses its concern and participates in international counter-terrorism efforts in South Asia. Historical involvement, from the Cold War to the “War on Terror”, shaped the region’s security landscape. U.S. operations have included support for regional counter-terrorism initiatives, intelligence sharing, and training programs to prevent extremist expansion. The withdrawal of U.S. troops from Afghanistan in 2021 had a harsh impact and led to an array of outcomes, including humanitarian distress and opportunities for extremist groups to expand across the region.¹⁰

Lashkar-e-Taiba

Lashkar-e-Taiba is a militant Islamist group founded in 1987 in Pakistan by Hafiz Muhammad Saeed and others during the period of the Soviet–Afghan War. It follows a Salafi Islamist ideology and aims to establish Islamic rule in South Asia, with a primary focus on integrating the disputed Kashmir region into Pakistan. The group has also operated through front organizations, such as The Resistance Front, which has most recently killed 26 civilians in Indian-administered Kashmir in 2025¹¹. Lashkar-e-Taiba has been the subject of ongoing international concern, with allegations that elements within Pakistan have at times tolerated or supported it.¹²

¹⁰ <https://www.state.gov/reports/country-reports-on-terrorism-2023>

¹¹ <https://edition.cnn.com/2025/04/24/india/pahalgam-india-pakistan-attack-explainer-intl-hnk/>

¹² <https://www.theguardian.com/world/2025/may/07/kashmir-crisis-pakistan-terrorist-groups-infrastructure>

V. Timeline of Events

Date	Description of Event
14 August 1947	The beginning of the Kashmir War between India and Pakistan following the partition of British India
1955–1975	The Vietnam War
1967–1975	The Cambodian Civil War
1979 - 1989	The Soviet-Afghan war leads to the rise of the Mujahideen, precursors to today's Taliban.
8 December 1985	The South Asian Association for Regional Cooperation (SAARC) was created in order to promote the welfare of the people of South Asia ¹³
1992 - 1996	The Afghan Civil War
7 October 2001	The United States began military action in Afghanistan, thus declaring the “War on Terror” as a response to the 9/11 attacks
26 November 2008	Lashkar-e-Taiba’s infamous Mumbai attacks
2 May 2013	Osama Bin Laden is eliminated in Pakistan by United States Special Forces in Operation Neptune Spear
1 February 2021	Beginning of the Myanmar Civil War
30 August 2021	The withdrawal of U.S. troops from Afghanistan
30 December 2024	15,000 Taliban troops were deployed to the Pakistan-Afghanistan border in response to the ongoing confrontations
22 April 2025	The Pahalgam Massacre
19 March 2026	Pakistan is declared the country currently most affected by terrorism by the Global Terrorism Index

¹³ <https://www.un-ilibrary.org/content/books/9789210477024s004-c024/read>



Lashkar-e-Taiba rally on a public street in Lahore, Pakistan

VI. Relevant UN Treaties and Events

- **United Nations Security Council Resolution 1373 (2001)**
- **United Nations Security Council Resolution 1540 (2004)**
- **United Nations Security Council Resolution 1642 (2005)**
- **United Nations Security Council Resolution 2178 (2014)**

The Security Council decided, in addition to other measures, South Asian countries' obligation to submit compliance reports to the Counter-Terrorism Committee (CTC), as well as the illegality of providing aid to non-state actors that attempt to develop, acquire, manufacture, possess, transport, transfer, or use nuclear, chemical or biological weapons and their means of delivery, in particular for terrorist purposes.¹⁴

- **ASEAN-India Cooperation on Counter-Terrorism (2004)**

While the SAARC has become dormant following the intensified rivalry between India and Pakistan in the early 2010s, there have been more concentrated efforts against terrorism, mostly limited to intelligence sharing and border security.¹⁵

- **International Convention for the Suppression of the Financing of Terrorism (1999)**

Cutting off funding from terrorist organizations continues to be of vital importance in the larger fight against terrorism. The convention strengthened financial regulations and ties all signatory states to track and block funding for groups such as ISIS or the Taliban.¹⁶

VII. Previous Attempts to Solve the Issues

- **South Asian Association for Regional Cooperation (SAARC)**

The South Asian Association for Regional Cooperation was created on the 8th of December 1985 in order to promote the welfare of the peoples of South Asia and to improve their quality of life; to accelerate economic growth, social progress, and cultural development in the region and to provide all individuals the opportunity to live in dignity and to realize their

¹⁴ <https://disarmament.unoda.org/wmd/sc1540/>

¹⁵ <https://asean.org/asean-india-joint-declaration-for-cooperation-to-combat-international-terrorism-2/>

¹⁶ <https://gatewayhouse.in/combating-terror-financing-through-saarc/>

full potential. SAARC also aims to strengthen cooperation with other developing countries and to cooperate with international and regional organizations with similar aims and purposes. Regional cooperation has been recognized as a crucial element in addressing the issue of terrorism, especially in South Asia. Organizations such as the South Asian Association for Regional Cooperation (SAARC) have sought to promote collaboration among member states. However, political tensions and an increase in government corruption have often diminished the effectiveness of such efforts. Multilateral initiatives, including intelligence sharing and joint operations, have shown promise, but there is a compelling need for improvement.

- **International Security Assistance Force (ISAF)**

The ISAF, established by UN Security Council Resolution 1368, was meant to provide the support needed for the creation of a new Afghan state following the 2001 U.S. invasion of the country. As a complimentary goal, however, it sought to eliminate Taliban influence and to further stabilize the region¹⁷. With over 130.000 personnel being stationed in 700 military bases¹⁸ across Afghanistan, the international coalition meant to eradicate extremist violence in the region only strengthened their resolve. The end of the war on terror in Afghanistan was marked by a bitter retreat of all western forces and, retrospectively, has “achieved” the opposite of its intended goal.

VIII. Possible Solutions

Addressing the issue of terrorism in the South Asian region is complex and it requires a comprehensive and coordinated approach that involves not only national governments but also regional and international stakeholders. Strengthening border security, enhancing intelligence sharing, and implementing disarmament programs are essential components of any effective strategy to tackle terrorism.

- **Border Security Improvements**

Enhancing border security is a crucial factor in order to help reduce the number of cross-border illegal operations in the South Asian region. Seeing as unstable, porous borders

¹⁷ <https://www.nato.int/en/what-we-do/operations-and-missions/isafs-mission-in-afghanistan-2001-2014>

¹⁸ https://fpif.org/the_700_military_bases_of_afghanistan/

are one of the main facilitators of the spread of terrorism, it is imperative that nations take action towards strengthening their cross-border security. This involves implementing coordinated and comprehensive border management strategies, which require close collaboration among competent authorities at border locations. Strengthening inter-agency cooperation and international partnerships can further amplify these efforts, ensuring that cross-border operations are seamless and effective.

- **Intelligence collaboration**

Effective intelligence-sharing among South Asian nations is vital for preventing attacks and dismantling terrorist cells. By establishing strong communication channels and collaborative frameworks (such as the previously mentioned SAARC), countries can share critical information regarding terrorist activity, methods and tactics. By sending trained professionals to the areas in need, we can much more safely take control of the issue and tackle it firsthand. This collaborative approach enables timely interventions and facilitates collaboration towards the common goal of international peace and security.

- **Disarmament programs**

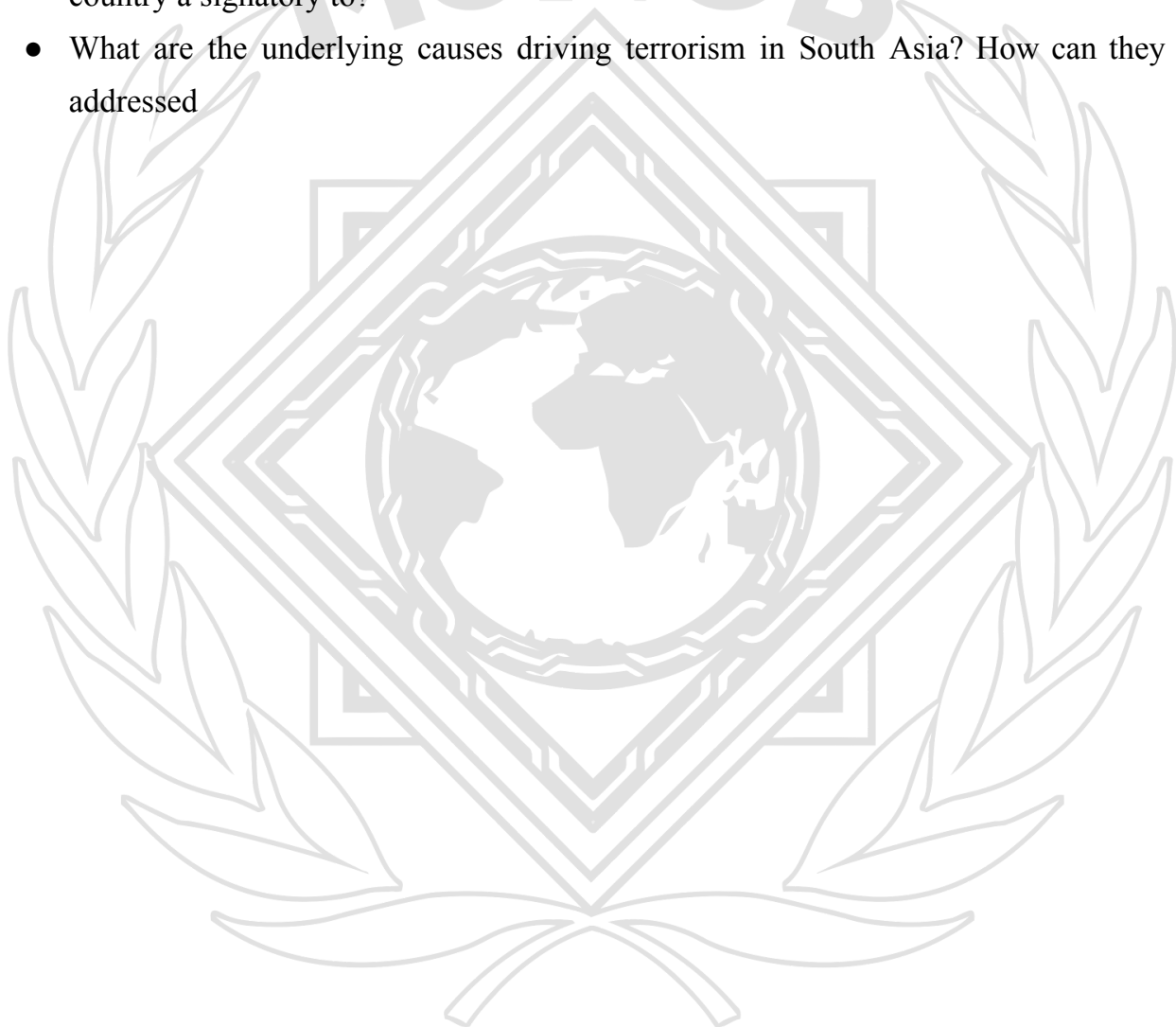
Disarmament initiatives play a significant role in reducing the availability of illicit supplies in South Asia, as they aim at tackling the root of the problem: terrorist groups, violent attacks, etc. By ensuring peaceful communication between key actors, we can reach a consensus that can gradually lead to a complete pacification of high-risk zones.

- **Cessation of government-sponsored conflict**

Armed conflicts between national militaries only serve to worsen the regional situation. Rivalries, such as the one between India and Pakistan, which led to the collapse of the SAARC, have rendered the entirety of South Asia unable to form a coherent response to terrorist attacks. To pacify terrorists, countries must first make peace with each other.

Questions delegates should consider during Research

- How is your country's national security affected by terrorism?
- Is your country actively sponsoring terrorism?
- What measures has your country implemented to tackle terrorism?
- Is your country involved in regional security alliances or cooperative initiatives addressing this issue?
- What international treaties or agreements that pertain to inhibiting terrorism is your country a signatory to?
- What are the underlying causes driving terrorism in South Asia? How can they be addressed



IX. Sources

Introduction:

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- https://fpif.org/the_700_military_bases_of_afghanistan/

Further Reading and Useful Links:

- <https://www.visionofhumanity.org/maps/global-terrorism-index/#/>
- <https://www.unodc.org/e4j/fr/terrorism/module-2/key-issues/radicalization-violent-extremism.html>
- <https://www.amnesty.org/en/latest/education/2021/09/universalizing-human-rights/>
- <https://press.un.org/en/2020/sc14093.doc.htm>
- <https://www.dw.com/en/taliban-afghanistan-pakistan-clashes-border-terrorism-ttp/a-74335259>

